young men and women during the Republic Day parades in Delhi and in the states.

Ethics, morality and propriety are issues that are gaining relevance more and more, particularly with regard to conduct of officers in higher ranks. Similarly, corruption has become endemic in our country and it has raised its ugly head in the armed forces too. It has been a perception that it was always there to some degree in the domain of contracts in works, supplies, clothing, stores and procurements. But by and large, the fabric of morality and probity in the armed forces was unblemished. The armed forces have been known to take action promptly against defaulters. Unfortunately, today, this disease has not left even the highest ranks unscathed. In the recent past, a few incidents have been played up by sections of the media, in some cases quite unfairly. The challenge has to be met squarely and collectively. We must ensure that the moral and ethical compass of all ranks of the armed forces does not deviate and lose direction. Therefore, we need to take urgent remedial measures, and the senior ranks have to show the way by displaying unimpeachable higher values and conduct for which the armed forces are renowned and revered by our countrymen.

We need to educate and forewarn the armed forces against adverse and corroding influences of some segments of society. It was reassuring to know of a 'public reverence survey' conducted by MODE on the occasion of the golden jubilee of our independence, in which the military scored over 80 per cent for honesty, bravery, efficiency and contribution to the nation and did better than civil servants, lawyers, doctors and businessmen. In another survey, carried out by *India Today* on India's fifty-fifth anniversary as a nation, it was heartening to see that the armed forces were rated as the first among fifty-five organizations or issues that Indians were proud of. Notwithstanding this, we must understand that in our context, 'value-based leadership' has today assumed greater relevance than before.